



RELOCATION GUIDE

Newcastle

Awabakal Country

A relocation guide for healthcare professionals and their families. The work, the neighbourhoods, the money and the weekends in Newcastle.

A real city. The surf ten minutes away.

Newcastle is New South Wales's second city: a former steel town at the mouth of the Hunter River that has reinvented itself around health, education and the coast. Its major teaching hospital serves a region far larger than the city, the beaches start at the edge of the CBD, and Sydney is about two hours down the motorway when you want it.

~170,000

people in the city, in a
Hunter region of
~700,000

2nd

largest city in New South
Wales

~2 hrs

by road to Sydney

~45 min

to Hunter Valley cellar
doors

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Guides describe places, not employers. Hospitals are described rather than named, and salaries, visas and registration rules change, so we confirm the detail with you directly.

Why clinicians choose Newcastle

Newcastle offers a combination few Australian cities can match: a genuine tertiary caseload, surf beaches within walking distance of the city centre, and a life that costs noticeably less than Sydney's.



Newcastle doesn't ask you to give up the city to get the beach. It gives you both, ten minutes apart, with a serious hospital in between.

Newcastle, or **Newy** as most Australians call it, grew up around coal and steel. Since the old steelworks closed in 1999 the city has rebuilt itself around health, education and its working port, and the result is a confident, outdoorsy regional city with its own personality. The University of Newcastle brings a lively student population, the inner suburbs have a thriving café and dining scene, and the coastline is the kind most capital cities would envy.

For clinicians, the pull is the work. The city's major tertiary referral and trauma hospital is the referral centre for a stretch of regional New South Wales far larger than the Hunter itself, so the caseload runs broader and busier than the city's own size would suggest. It is a teaching hospital with strong university links, and many clinicians find they take on responsibility earlier here than they would on a big Sydney rotation.

The Hunter is also classed as **regional** for skilled migration purposes, which can open visa pathways that Sydney does not. It is worth asking us how that applies to your profession and situation.

WHAT YOU GAIN

Surf before your shift

Newcastle Beach, Bar Beach and Merewether sit minutes from the city centre, with ocean baths for gentler swims.

A broad, busy caseload

A tertiary centre with a huge regional catchment, so the case mix runs wider than the city's size suggests.

Teaching built in

Strong links with the University of Newcastle's medical and health programs mean students and trainees are part of daily life.

Wine country and whales nearby

The Hunter Valley is about 45 minutes inland and Port Stephens under an hour up the coast.

Better value than Sydney

Housing costs meaningfully less than Sydney's, for a city two hours up the motorway.

GOOD TO KNOW

Some services are in Sydney

A small number of highly specialised services are still referred to Sydney's largest hospitals. Ask how that works for your specialty.

A car is useful

The inner city is walkable and served by light rail, but beyond it most households rely on a car.

A city still evolving

The renewal is real and part of the city's energy; a few neighbourhoods are still mid-transformation.

Popular beach suburbs

Sea-changers from Sydney have made the beachside suburbs sought after, so a few streets inland often gives better value.

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It suits you best if...

If you're looking for big-city scale and anonymity, Sydney may suit you better. If you're drawn to a serious caseload, a friendly professional community where you get to know people quickly, and a swim on a Tuesday evening, Newcastle could be a wonderful choice.



Newcastle's city beaches are part of everyday life, not just weekends



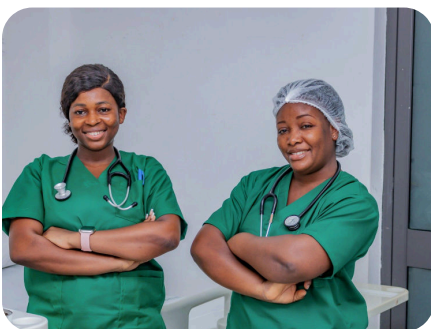
Surf after work is an ordinary pleasure on this coast



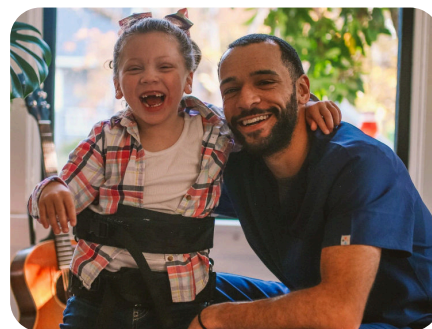
Surfing is for every age on this coast



Wine country is under an hour from the city



Teams that welcome overseas colleagues



Allied health roles span hospital and community care



A tertiary centre means specialist units such as neonatal care

Newcastle at a glance

Newcastle sits where the Hunter River meets the Pacific, about 160 kilometres north of Sydney. Here is the geography, the climate and a little of the history.

The city centre is built on a narrow neck of land between the harbour and the ocean, with Nobbys Head and its lighthouse guarding the river mouth. From there the suburbs spread south along a string of surf beaches towards Lake Macquarie, Australia's largest coastal saltwater lake, and west towards Maitland and the vineyards of the Hunter Valley. Across the harbour, Stockton and the long sweep of Stockton Beach lead north to Port Stephens.

Newcastle was founded in 1804 as a coal and penal settlement and became Australia's steel city for most of the twentieth century. It remains one of the world's largest coal export ports, and you will see the ships waiting offshore from almost any beach. Today the economy rests on health, education, the port, and a growing tech and creative sector.



The heritage Customs House on the harbour foreshore, a short walk from the city's beaches

Summer

DEC – FEB

Warm to hot, roughly 18 to 27°C, with afternoon sea breezes and the occasional summer storm. Beach season in full swing.

Autumn

MAR – MAY

Mild and settled, around 14 to 23°C. Many locals think it is the loveliest time of year, and the sea stays warm into April.

Winter

JUN – AUG

Cool, clear days of about 7 to 17°C. Mild by UK standards, with plenty of sunshine for coastal walks.

Spring

SEP – NOV

Warming up, around 12 to 22°C, with whale-watching season along the coast and the beaches filling again.



Worth planning for

Like much of the east coast, Newcastle occasionally sees an east-coast low bringing heavy rain and strong surf, and parts of the wider Hunter can flood. When you look at homes in the river towns, it is worth checking flood information with the local council.

A note on Country



The Awabakal people are the Traditional Custodians of the Newcastle area, with the Worimi people recognised further north around Port Stephens.



Taking time to learn whose Country you live and work on is genuinely appreciated here.



Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings and events across the region, including at hospitals and universities.

Working in healthcare in Newcastle

Healthcare in Newcastle runs bigger than the city itself: its major teaching hospital is the referral centre for a large part of regional New South Wales.

Public healthcare in Newcastle is run by the NSW public health system through the local health district, which covers one of the largest areas of any district in the state, from the coast across the Hunter and up into the New England tablelands. At its centre is the region's **major tertiary referral and trauma hospital**, a large teaching campus west of the city centre, supported by a network of district and community hospitals, including a newer major hospital at Maitland.

Alongside the public system sits a substantial private and not-for-profit sector, with private hospitals, day surgery centres, imaging and allied health practices across Newcastle, Lake Macquarie and the Hunter. Many clinicians combine public and private work over a career here.



A tertiary caseload with a very large regional catchment behind it

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major tertiary and trauma referral centre for the region

Huge

catchment, stretching well beyond the Hunter

Teaching

strong links with the University of Newcastle

Because the tertiary centre serves such a large region, clinicians see a breadth of presentations that a city of Newcastle's size would not otherwise generate. Retrieval and transfer become everyday skills, and smaller specialist teams mean your judgement is trusted early. The University of Newcastle's medical program, run jointly with the University of New England, puts students and trainees on the wards as a matter of course, and there is a strong research culture across the campus.

A small number of the most highly specialised services are still delivered in Sydney, so part of working here is knowing the referral pathways for your area. That is easy to find out at interview, and most clinicians find the trade very much in their favour: broader hands-on practice, with Sydney's quaternary centres there when a patient needs them.

WARDS, ED, ICU, THEATRES, MATERNITY

Nurses and midwives

Roles across the tertiary campus, district hospitals and community services, with clear pathways into specialty and senior roles.

HOSPITAL AND GENERAL PRACTICE

Doctors

Tertiary specialties in the city, broad rural-generalist experience across the region, and general practice in growing communities.

IMAGING, PHYSIO, OT AND MORE

Allied health

Radiographers, sonographers, physiotherapists and OTs work across public hospitals, private imaging groups and community practice.



Regional care often means getting to know patients and families well



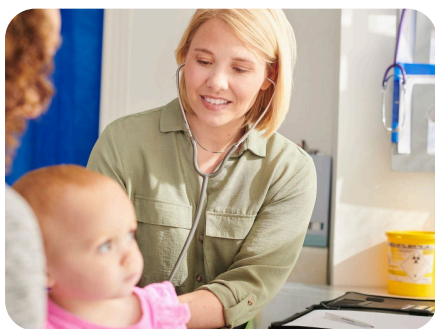
Imaging and allied health roles span public hospitals and private practice

What to ask at interview

- ☐ How far does the department's regional catchment extend, and what does that mean for retrievals and transfers?
- ☐ Which cases are referred to Sydney, and how does that work day to day?
- ☐ What teaching and research involvement comes with the university link?
- ☐ How many senior colleagues are in your specialty specifically?
- ☐ What CPD time and funding is provided, and what does the roster look like?
- ☐ If the role is outside the city, how far is the commute from the suburbs you are considering?



Theatre and critical care teams support the region's tertiary caseload



Paediatric care for families across the region



Maternity services in the city and across the Hunter



General practice is growing with the region's population

Where to live in Newcastle

Newcastle's suburbs run from heritage streets you can walk to the beach from, to leafy family suburbs near the main hospital campus and roomier homes around the lake.

~5 MIN TO THE CBD · BEACHES & HERITAGE

Newcastle East, Cooks Hill & The Hill

Terrace houses and apartments a stroll from Newcastle Beach, Darby Street cafés and the harbour. Ideal if you want to walk everywhere.

~10 MIN · SURF & CAFÉS

Merewether, Bar Beach & The Junction

Much-loved beachside suburbs with ocean baths, good schools and a village feel. Sought after, so a few streets back often gives better value.

~10 MIN · DINING & RAIL

Hamilton & Islington

The inner-west, built around Beaumont Street's restaurants, with train stations and an easy run to the main hospital campus.

~10–15 MIN · FAMILIES & PARKS

Lambton, New Lambton & Adamstown

Leafy, established suburbs with parks, pools and schools, close to the main hospital campus and the university.

~20–30 MIN · LAKE & SPACE

Lake Macquarie: Charlestown to Warners Bay

Waterside living around the lake, with bigger blocks, boating and shared paths, and a straightforward drive into the city.

~35–45 MIN · SPACE & GROWTH

Maitland & the Hunter fringe

A historic river town and a fast-growing corridor towards wine country, with new estates, acreage and a newer major hospital.

The single biggest factor in what you will pay is how close you live to the water. Clinicians who arrive set on a beachfront address often find that moving two or three streets inland, or out to Lambton, New Lambton or Adamstown, gives them more home for the same budget and only a few extra minutes to the sand.

If you have children, look at school catchments at the same time as homes, since in New South Wales your address decides your local public school. Many families rent for the first six to twelve months, learn the city, then choose where to settle.



Newcastle's southern beaches, where the city's most popular suburbs meet the sea



A quiet weekday on one of Newcastle's southern beaches

Choosing your area

- ☐ Fix your work site first: the main hospital campus sits west of the city centre, and some roles are in Maitland or the wider Hunter.
- ☐ Decide how much daily beach access matters to you; it is the biggest price difference across the city.
- ☐ Check school catchments for the exact address before you sign a lease.
- ☐ Shortlist two or three suburbs and drive the commute at peak time.
- ☐ Expect to apply for rentals with ID, references and proof of income, and to pay a bond lodged with NSW Fair Trading.

Getting around Newcastle

The inner city is walkable and served by light rail, buses and a harbour ferry, all on the Opal card. For most people beyond the inner suburbs, a car makes daily life easiest.

OPAL CARD

Light rail

A short, frequent line from Newcastle Interchange through the city centre to Newcastle Beach, handy if you live or work near it.

OPAL CARD

Buses and the Stockton ferry

A bus network covers Newcastle and Lake Macquarie, and a little ferry crosses the harbour to Stockton in a few minutes.

OPAL CARD

Trains

Suburban lines run to Maitland, the Hunter and Lake Macquarie, and intercity trains run down the coast to Sydney.

MOST HOUSEHOLDS

Driving

The M1 Pacific Motorway runs south to Sydney; most suburbs, the hospital campuses and the wider Hunter are easiest by car.

Opal is the same card used across Sydney and the rest of the NSW network, and you can also tap on and off with a contactless bank card or phone. If you can find a home within walking distance of the light rail or the inner beaches, daily life becomes wonderfully simple; otherwise plan on a car, and for many two-adult households, two.

You can drive in New South Wales on a current overseas licence for a while after arriving, but once you are a resident you will need to convert to a NSW licence through Service NSW, usually within six months. UK and Irish licence holders can generally convert without a driving test.

FROM THE INNER CITY TO	ROUGHLY	GOOD TO KNOW
Merewether Beach	~10 min by car	The surf beach many people swim at before or after a shift
Main hospital campus	~10–15 min by car	Buses run too; check parking arrangements with your employer
University of Newcastle (Callaghan)	~15 min by car	Also on the train line

FROM THE INNER CITY TO	ROUGHLY	GOOD TO KNOW
Newcastle Airport	~25–30 min by car	Domestic flights; most long-haul connections via Sydney
Maitland	~35–40 min by car or train	Regular suburban trains
Sydney	~2 hrs by car, ~2.5–3 hrs by train	Easier outside peak times on the M1



Shared paths along the coast and lake make cycling an easy family outing



A double-decker train in Sydney: intercity services on the same network link Newcastle with Sydney

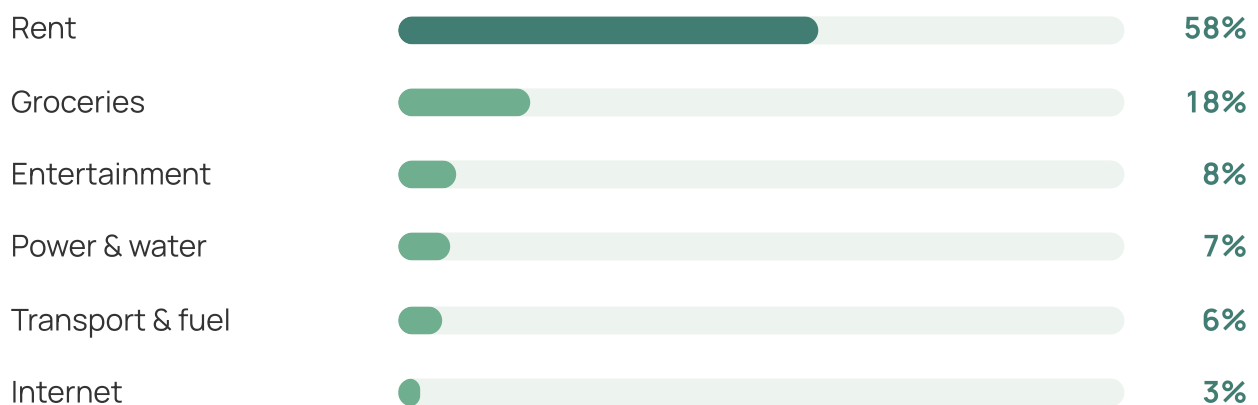
What it costs to live here

Living costs in Newcastle are one of its clearest attractions: meaningfully lower than Sydney's, for a city two hours up the coast, though the most popular beach suburbs have narrowed the gap.

We don't print prices in these guides, because a figure that is right today can mislead you in a year. What changes slowly is the shape of a typical month, and the handful of choices that make the biggest difference. For up-to-date numbers, use the comparison links in the local directory and compare Newcastle with the city you live in now.

As everywhere in Australia, housing is the biggest line. The good news is that in Newcastle it takes a noticeably smaller bite of a clinician's income than the same home would in Sydney.

Where a typical month goes



Indicative proportions for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices change every quarter.

What makes the biggest difference

- ✓ **How close to the water you live.** Merewether, Bar Beach and The Junction carry a premium; a few streets inland, or Lambton, New Lambton and Adamstown, can be noticeably better value.
- ✓ **Trips to Sydney.** Fuel, Sydney tolls and the odd overnight add up if friends or family are there.
- ✓ **One car or two.** Living near the light rail or inner beaches can save a second car, one of the bigger running costs people forget.
- ✓ **Summer power.** Air conditioning is welcome in a humid Hunter summer, and older homes can be less well insulated, so ask about insulation and the cooling system before you sign.



Merewether Ocean Baths: free to swim in, and one of the best things about living here

IN SHORT

- ✓ Newcastle costs meaningfully less to live in than Sydney, especially for housing.
- ✓ Your biggest lever is how close to the beach you choose to live.
- ✓ Many of the best things here are free: beaches, ocean baths, coastal walks and parks.
- ✓ Ask us about pay and allowances for your profession; we're happy to talk you through the range.



Family healthcare close to home



Breakfast at the campsite: simple pleasures cost little



Spotting Australia's wildlife costs nothing at all



Pay and allowances vary by role, so ask us for the range in your profession



SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

What I tell people about Newcastle

Newcastle is the city I find people fall for once they've visited. It has the things clinicians tell me they miss in big cities: time, space and the sea, without giving up a serious hospital. You can finish a shift, be in the water at Merewether twenty minutes later and still have the evening to yourself.

What I love about it is how friendly and down to earth it is. You will know people quickly, at work and on the school run, and the Malayali and wider Indian communities here are warm and well organised. The Hunter Valley for lunch, Port Stephens for the dolphins and Sydney two hours away for a concert make it a very easy place to build a life.

If you want a busy, varied caseload and a life that feels like a permanent holiday at the weekend, I will always suggest you take a good look at Newcastle.

Sophie Careem

Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing

Food, shopping and everyday life

Newcastle's food scene has grown up alongside the city: relaxed coastal cafés, a serious dining strip in Hamilton, and Hunter Valley produce and wine close enough to shape the everyday menu.

DINING STRIP

Beaumont Street, Hamilton

The city's best-known eat street, with a long run of restaurants, bars and cafés and a strong Italian heritage.

CAFÉS AND SMALL BARS

Darby Street & the East End

The revitalised inner core: brunch spots, bookshops, galleries and small bars a short walk from the beach.

WATERFRONT

Honeysuckle & the harbour

Harbourside restaurants and bars along the foreshore, lovely on a summer evening.

~45 MIN INLAND

Hunter Valley produce

Cellar doors, cheese, olive oil and farm-gate produce, with fresh seafood from the coast closer to home.



Weekend brunch is something of a Newcastle institution



The coffee is taken seriously here



Indian and South Asian groceries and restaurants are easy to find in the inner west

For the weekly shop, Woolworths and Coles are everywhere, ALDI is popular for value, and IGA and independent grocers fill in the gaps, especially around Maitland and the Hunter. There are Indian and Asian grocers in and around Hamilton and the city, a Costco in Lake Macquarie, and the Newcastle City Farmers Market at the showground on most Sunday mornings.

Newcastle is a welcoming, increasingly diverse city. There is a long-established Malayali community whose Onam celebrations draw hundreds of families, a large Indian community network, an active multicultural sector, a historic Greek community in Hamilton, mosques, a Hindu mandir, a gurdwara and a Syro-Malabar Catholic mission. The local directory lists where to start.

A few local words

- ✓ **Newy:** the affectionate nickname for Newcastle.
- ✓ **Nobbys:** Nobbys Beach and the lighthouse headland, the city's best-known landmark.
- ✓ **The Hunter:** the wider region, including the wine country inland.
- ✓ **Nor'easter:** the cooling sea breeze locals wait for on hot summer afternoons.



Sophie's tip

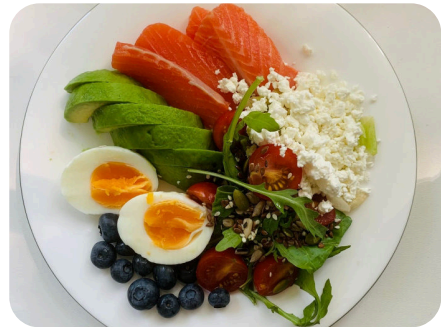
Book ahead for Beaumont Street on a Friday or Saturday night. Newcastle's dining reputation has caught up with the rest of the city's renewal, and the best tables go early.



Asian grocers and restaurants are easy to find



Sushi is an everyday lunch in Australia



Fresh, healthy café food is easy to find



The classic Australian brunch



A good breakfast before an early shift

What people do at the weekend

Newcastle's best weekends rarely need a flight: surf and ocean baths in town, wine country inland, and dolphins and dunes up the coast.



Nobbys Beach on a summer weekend, with the lighthouse on the headland

A typical Newcastle weekend starts with a swim or a walk along the coast. The Bathers Way runs about six kilometres from Nobbys to Merewether past every city beach, the Bogey Hole and the ocean baths, with cafés along the way. Weekends in summer bring surf carnivals and Nippers; in winter, coastal walks and long lunches.

Further out, Lake Macquarie is perfect for paddleboarding, sailing and cycling the lakeside paths, Blackbutt Reserve has free bushwalks and native wildlife, and the Hunter Valley is close enough for a casual lunch rather than an expedition.

IN TOWN

The Bathers Way

A spectacular coastal walk linking Nobbys, the city beaches, the Bogey Hole and Merewether Ocean Baths.

~20-30 MIN

Lake Macquarie

Paddleboarding, sailing, lakeside cafés and long shared paths around Australia's largest coastal saltwater lake.

~45 MIN-1 HR

Hunter Valley

Cellar doors, long lunches, concerts in the vineyards and sunrise hot-air balloon flights.



Nippers and surf lessons are a rite of passage on this coast

~30 MIN-1 HR

Stockton Bight & Port Stephens

Huge sand dunes, dolphin cruises, whale watching in season and calm bays for children.



Calm-water paddling is a favourite on the lake and in the bays

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Good to know

Swim between the red and yellow flags at patrolled beaches, as rips are a natural feature of this coast. The ocean baths and the Bogey Hole are lovely, gentler alternatives on a big-surf day.



Kayaking on Sydney Harbour



Lunch by the water at Circular Quay in Sydney



The train makes Sydney a car-free weekend away

Around Newcastle

Three easy roads out of the city: north to the dunes and dolphins of Port Stephens, west into the Hunter Valley and the Barrington Tops, and south along Lake Macquarie and the Central Coast towards Sydney.

Inland, the Hunter Valley is Australia's oldest wine region, famous for semillon and shiraz, with more than a hundred cellar doors around Pokolbin, along with restaurants, gardens and hot-air balloon flights. Beyond it, the World Heritage-listed Barrington Tops rise into cool rainforest and snow-gum country, a lovely overnight escape in summer.

Up the coast, Port Stephens offers dolphin cruises, whale watching between May and November, and the Stockton Bight dunes, the largest moving sand dunes in the southern hemisphere. To the south, Lake Macquarie and the Central Coast are a string of lakes, beaches and national parks, and Sydney is about two hours away for a show, a concert or the airport.

GETTING TO	ROUGHLY	WHY GO
Newcastle Beach & the city beaches	~5–10 min	The nearest surf beaches, right at the edge of the CBD. Swim between the flags.
Snowy Mountains ski fields (Perisher & Thredbo)	~7 hrs by car	Australia's biggest ski fields, a classic winter road trip or long weekend, roughly June to early October.
Sydney	~2 hrs by car	The nearest major city and the state capital: beaches, harbour, theatre and international flights.
Newcastle Airport	~25–30 min	Domestic flights to Brisbane, Melbourne and beyond; most international travel connects through Sydney.
Hunter Valley	~45 min–1 hr	Cellar doors, long lunches, gardens and balloon flights.
Port Stephens	~45 min–1 hr	Dolphins, whales in season, sand dunes and calm bays.
Lake Macquarie	~20–30 min	Sailing, paddling, lakeside cafés and cycle paths.
Barrington Tops	~2 hrs	World Heritage rainforest, waterfalls, cool mountain air and camping.

~45 MIN-1 HR WEST

Hunter Valley

A wine-country lunch is a perfectly ordinary Saturday here, not a special-occasion trip.

~45 MIN-1 HR NORTH

Port Stephens

Dolphin cruises, sandboarding on the dunes and family-friendly beaches at Nelson Bay.

~2 HRS NORTH-WEST

Barrington Tops

Rainforest walks, swimming holes and cosy cabins in cooler mountain air.

~1 HR SOUTH

The Central Coast

Beaches, lakes and national parks between Newcastle and Sydney, easy by car or train.

~2 HRS SOUTH

Sydney

Concerts, theatre, the harbour and the international airport, all within a day trip.



A glass among the vines: wine country is about 45 minutes from the city



Long lunches with local produce are a big part of a wine-country day



Sydney, about two hours south, for a weekend in the big city



Koalas live wild in parts of the region, and Port Stephens has a koala sanctuary



The Opera House: a concert in Sydney is an easy day trip



The Blue Mountains, west of Sydney: about three hours from Newcastle, and a favourite long weekend

Families and schools

Newcastle is a lovely place to grow up: beaches, bush and lake on the doorstep, sport every weekend, and a relaxed pace that leaves room for family life.



Primary school in New South Wales runs from Kindergarten to Year 6



Beach days are an easy, free family outing

Schooling in New South Wales has three sectors. **Government (public) schools** educate most children and include selective high schools, such as Merewether High School, and specialist schools for the performing arts. **Catholic schools**, run by the Diocese of Maitland-Newcastle, are often more affordable than families expect. **Independent schools** range from small community and faith schools to long-established colleges such as Newcastle Grammar School.

Children start in Kindergarten, usually in the year they turn five (they can start if they turn five by 31 July, and must be at school by six). Primary school runs from Kindergarten to Year 6 and high school from Year 7 to Year 12, finishing with the Higher School Certificate (HSC). The school year has four terms, starting in late January or early February.

School fees on a temporary visa

- ✓ Most temporary visa holders in New South Wales pay a temporary resident fee for their children to attend a government school.
- ✓ There is good news for many clinicians: children of subclass 482 visa holders attending a regional school are exempt from the tuition fee, and the eligible regional postcodes include Newcastle and the Hunter.
- ✓ Other visa types, and the application process itself, follow the NSW Department of Education's Temporary Residents Program (DE International). Check the current rules for your visa subclass and address there before you weigh an offer, and we will help you work it through.
- ✓ Permanent residents and citizens attend government schools on the same basis as local families.

Choosing a school

- ☐ Check the catchment at the exact address with the NSW school finder before you sign a lease; local public schools must take children who live in their catchment.
- ☐ Some fast-growing suburbs have schools that fill quickly, so research schools and homes together.
- ☐ Catholic and independent schools set their own fees and many have waiting lists, so enquire early.
- ☐ Ask about English as an Additional Language or Dialect (EAL/D) support if your child is still learning English.

What children tend to love here

- ✓ Nippers at the local surf club on summer Sunday mornings.
- ✓ Blackbutt Reserve's koalas, kangaroos and bush trails, free to visit.
- ✓ Speers Point Park's huge playground and the lakeside cycle paths.
- ✓ The ocean baths, the Bogey Hole and calm swimming at the lake.
- ✓ The Newcastle Museum and Fort Scratchley for rainy days and history.
- ✓ Weekend sport for every age: football, netball, cricket, rugby league and Little Athletics.

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Early childhood

Children can attend long day care, family day care or a community preschool before school. The Australian Government's Child Care Subsidy helps with the cost for eligible families, and the NSW Government's Start Strong program supports preschool fee relief in the year or two before school. Popular centres have waiting lists, so register early.



Early learning centres and preschools are spread across the city



Lake and harbour paddling make for memorable school holidays

CALLAGHAN AND CITY CAMPUSES

University of Newcastle

A well-regarded university with medicine, nursing, midwifery and allied health programs, and a modern campus in the city centre.

VOCATIONAL STUDY

TAFE NSW

Campuses across the Hunter offering practical qualifications, and free English classes for eligible migrants through the Adult Migrant English Program.



Creative early years at preschool and primary school



High school runs from Year 7 to Year 12, finishing with the HSC



Outdoor play is part of every day in early childhood education

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Come for the caseload, stay for the swim before work.

Your Newcastle address book

Newcastle has a warm and well-organised Malayali community, whose Onam celebration brings together hundreds of families each year, alongside a large Indian community network, a historic Greek community in Hamilton and an active multicultural sector. A migrant resource centre that has served the Hunter since 1981, free English classes and a growing spread of temples, mosques and churches make settling in easier.

COUNCILS & LOCAL SERVICES

City of Newcastle

The council for the city: libraries, pools, ocean baths, parks, events and waste collection

newcastle.nsw.gov.au

Lake Macquarie City Council

Council services for the lake suburbs, from Charlestown to Morisset

lakemac.com.au

Maitland City Council

Council services for Maitland and the growth corridor to the west

maitland.nsw.gov.au

Port Stephens Council

Council services for Raymond Terrace, Medowie, Nelson Bay and the bays

portstephens.nsw.gov.au

Service NSW

Licence conversion, car registration and many NSW Government services in one place

13 77 88 service.nsw.gov.au

Newcastle Transport

Light rail, bus and Stockton ferry timetables and Opal information for Newcastle

newcastletransport.info

Transport for NSW trip planner

Trip planner and timetables for trains across the region and to Sydney

transportnsw.info

healthdirect

Free 24-hour health advice from a registered nurse; call 000 in an emergency

1800 022 222 healthdirect.gov.au

NSW Fair Trading

Renting rights, rental bonds and consumer advice

13 32 20 fairtrading.nsw.gov.au

COMMUNITY & CULTURAL ASSOCIATIONS

Humsam Malayali Association of Newcastle

The Hunter's long-established Malayali community association, with around 700 members; runs Onam and other cultural celebrations each year.

Mosaic Multicultural Connections

The Hunter's migrant resource centre (formerly Northern Settlement Services), helping migrants settle since 1981, with family, youth and aged care support.

mosaicmc.org.au

Hunter Multicultural Communities

Multicultural friendship groups, celebrations, trips and a community garden across Newcastle and the Hunter. 2A Platt Street, Waratah.

02 4960 8248 huntermulticultural.org.au

Multicultural Neighbourhood Centre

Free English classes, information and social activities for people from non-English-speaking backgrounds. 3 Illalung Road, Lambton.

02 4965 5291 mncinc.org.au

Hunter African Communities Council

Community council for people of African backgrounds in the Hunter: information sessions, Harmony Day events, social soccer and multicultural nights.

Adult Migrant English Program (TAFE NSW)

Free English classes for eligible migrants and their partners, with TAFE campuses across the Hunter.
tafensw.edu.au/programs/adult-migrant-english-program

Settlement Hub: Newcastle (Multicultural NSW)

The NSW Government's list of settlement, English and community services in Newcastle.
settlementhub.multicultural.nsw.gov.au/find-services/newcastle

FACEBOOK GROUPS

Indians in Newcastle, Maitland & Hunter

A large social group (around 17,000 members) for networking, advice and cultural events across the region.
facebook.com/groups/1274854580365946

PLACES OF WORSHIP

Sacred Heart Cathedral, Hamilton

The Catholic cathedral of the Diocese of Maitland-Newcastle.
sacredhearthamilton.org.au

St Mary's Syro-Malabar Mission, Newcastle

Syro-Malabar Catholic community for the Hunter, part of the Eparchy of St Thomas the Apostle.
syromalabar.org.au/new-castle

Christ Church Cathedral

The Anglican cathedral on the hill above the city centre.
newcastleanglican.org.au/ministries/christ-church-cathedral

Greek Orthodox Parish of the Holy Apostles

Greek Orthodox parish at 11-17 Steel Street, Hamilton.

Newcastle Muslim Association

Runs the mosques at 6 Metcalfe Street, Wallsend, and 5 Victoria Street, Mayfield.

BAPS Shri Swaminarayan Mandir

Hindu mandir at 6 Margaret Street, Cardiff.
baps.org/newcastle

Newcastle Sikh Association

Gurdwara at 27 Marton Street, Shortland.

Newcastle Hebrew Congregation

Newcastle's historic Art Deco synagogue on Tyrrell Street, near Cooks Hill.

Tibetan Buddhist Meditation Centre

Buddhist meditation centre in Hamilton; check current details before visiting.

Rhema 99.7 local church directory

A directory of Christian churches across Newcastle and the Hunter, including Pentecostal and evangelical congregations.
rhema99.7.com.au/church

HALAL, KOSHER & INTERNATIONAL GROCERIES

Indian Superstore Newcastle

Indian groceries, spices and staples in Hamilton.

EIG Cash & Carry Newcastle

Asian groceries in a wholesale warehouse format.

Newcastle S-Mart

Asian supermarket with a wide range of cuisines.

KWON Mart

Asian supermarket.

University of Newcastle shopping guide

The university's list of international grocers and markets for students, useful for families too.
newcastle.edu.au/international/while-you-are-here/living-in-australia/shopping

SUPERMARKETS & MARKETS

Woolworths

Supermarkets across Newcastle, Lake Macquarie and the Hunter, with online delivery.

[woolworths.com.au](https://www.woolworths.com.au)

Coles

Supermarkets across the region, with online delivery and click and collect.

[coles.com.au](https://www.coles.com.au)

ALDI

Popular for good-value weekly shops.

[aldi.com.au](https://www.aldi.com.au)

Costco (Lake Macquarie)

Bulk groceries and household goods; membership required.

[costco.com.au](https://www.costco.com.au)

Newcastle City Farmers Market

Local produce, bread, coffee and food stalls at Newcastle Showground, Broadmeadow, most Sunday mornings.

Glendale Farmers and Artisans Market

Produce and artisan stalls at Stockland Glendale on Saturday mornings.

Newcastle Food & Flower Markets

Fresh produce and flowers at Sandgate, open all week.

SCHOOLS & UNIFORMS

NSW school finder

Find your local public school and check the catchment for an exact address.

education.nsw.gov.au/school-finder

Temporary Residents Program (DE International)

The NSW Department of Education's rules, fees and exemptions for children of temporary visa holders, including the regional exemption for subclass 482 visa holders.

deinternational.nsw.edu.au/study/schools/temporary-residents

Catholic Schools Office, Maitland-Newcastle

Catholic primary and secondary schools across Newcastle and the Hunter, with online enrolment.

mn.catholic.edu.au

Independent Schools NSW

The association representing independent schools across NSW, with a guide to its member schools.

isnsw.edu.au

School uniform shops

Most NSW schools sell uniforms through their own uniform shop (often run by the P&C) or a nominated local supplier; the school's website says where to buy, and many run second-hand sales.

HOUSING & AREAS

realestate.com.au

Australia's largest property site for rentals and sales.

[realestate.com.au](https://www.realestate.com.au)

Domain

Rental and sales listings, with suburb profiles.

[domain.com.au](https://www.domain.com.au)

Flatmates.com.au

Share accommodation, useful for a first few months.

[flatmates.com.au](https://www.flatmates.com.au)

Rental Bonds Online (NSW Fair Trading)

NSW Fair Trading holds rental bonds; lodge, view and claim your bond online.

nsw.gov.au/housing-and-construction/renting-a-place-to-live/residential-rental-bonds

Tenants' Union of NSW

Free renting factsheets and links to the local Tenants Advice and Advocacy Service for the Hunter.

[tenants.org.au](https://www.tenants.org.au)

GETTING AROUND

Newcastle Transport

Light rail, buses and the Stockton ferry: timetables, maps and Opal information.

[newcastletransport.info](https://www.newcastletransport.info)

Transport for NSW (transportnsw.info)

Trip planner and timetables for trains across the Hunter and to Sydney.

transportnsw.info

Opal

Manage your Opal card and top-ups; contactless bank cards also work.

opal.com.au

Service NSW

Convert your overseas driver licence (usually within six months of becoming a resident), register a car and more.

13 77 88 service.nsw.gov.au

COST COMPARISON LINKS

Numbeo: cost of living in Newcastle

Crowd-sourced prices to compare Newcastle with the city you are leaving; treat it as a ballpark.

numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Newcastle

NSW Government payments and assistance

NSW concessions, rebates and cost-of-living support, including the Savings Finder.

nsw.gov.au/money-and-taxes/concessions-and-rebates



Checked October 2026

Community groups, shops and pages change. If a link has moved or you know a group we should add, tell us and we will update the guide.

Numbers and websites to keep handy

The national services every newcomer uses, wherever in Australia you land.

EMERGENCIES & HEALTH ADVICE

Emergency services

Police, fire and ambulance, any time
000

Emergency from a mobile

Also connects to emergency services from any mobile phone
112

healthdirect

Free 24/7 health advice from a registered nurse
1800 022 222 [healthdirect.gov.au](https://www.healthdirect.gov.au)

Lifeline

24/7 crisis support and suicide prevention, by phone, text or chat
13 11 14 [lifeline.org.au](https://www.lifeline.org.au)

Poisons Information Centre

24/7 advice if someone may have been poisoned
13 11 26

Pregnancy, Birth and Baby

Free support for parents from pregnancy to preschool
1800 882 436 [pregnancybirthbaby.org.au](https://www.pregnancybirthbaby.org.au)

Private health insurance complaints

The Commonwealth Ombudsman's free complaints service
1300 737 299 [ombudsman.gov.au](https://www.ombudsman.gov.au)

VISAS, REGISTRATION & WORK

Department of Home Affairs

Visas, skilled occupation lists and processing times
immi.homeaffairs.gov.au

ImmiAccount

Lodge and track your visa application online
online.immi.gov.au

Register of migration agents (OMARA)

Check an agent is registered before you pay
mara.gov.au

Ahpra

National registration and the National Boards
1300 419 495 ahpra.gov.au

Fair Work Ombudsman

Awards, pay rates and your rights at work
13 13 94 [fairwork.gov.au](https://www.fairwork.gov.au)

HEALTHCARE FOR YOUR FAMILY

Medicare · Services Australia

Enrolment, cards, claims and reciprocal health care agreements
132 011 [servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare](https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare)

healthdirect service finder

Find a GP, pharmacy, urgent care or hospital near you
[healthdirect.gov.au/australian-health-services](https://www.healthdirect.gov.au/australian-health-services)

privatehealth.gov.au

Compare private health cover independently; run by the Commonwealth Ombudsman
[privatehealth.gov.au](https://www.privatehealth.gov.au)

SCHOOLS & CHILDCARE

NSW school finder

Government schools and catchments in New South Wales
[education.nsw.gov.au/school-finder](https://www.education.nsw.gov.au/school-finder)

Find my school (Victoria)

School zones for any Victorian address
[findmyschool.vic.gov.au](https://www.findmyschool.vic.gov.au)

Find a school (Queensland)

State schools and catchment areas
qld.gov.au/education/schools/find

Find a public school (WA)

Western Australian public schools and local-intake areas
wa.gov.au/service/education-and-training/school-education/find-public-school

School zones (South Australia)

Zone maps for government schools
education.sa.gov.au/parents-and-families/enrol-school-or-preschool/zones-catchments-and-capacity-management/maps-school-zones-enrolment-year

Find your local school (Tasmania)

Intake areas for Tasmanian government schools
decyp.tas.gov.au/learning/find-your-local-school

Priority enrolment areas (ACT)

Find a Canberra public school for your address
act.gov.au/education-and-training/find-a-school-and-enrol

Choose a school (NT)

Urban and remote schools in the Northern Territory
nt.gov.au/learning/primary-and-secondary-students/choose-a-school

Starting Blocks

Compare childcare services and quality ratings near you
startingblocks.gov.au

Child Care Subsidy

Eligibility, rates and how to apply
servicesaustralia.gov.au/child-care-subsidy

MONEY & HOME

Australian Taxation Office

Apply for your tax file number (TFN), tax and super
13 28 61 ato.gov.au

Moneysmart

Free, independent budgeting, super and banking tools
moneysmart.gov.au

SETTLING IN

TIS National

Free interpreting by phone, 24/7, in 150+ languages
131 450 tisnational.gov.au

Settle in Australia

Home Affairs' settlement topics and services for new arrivals
immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/settling-in-australia

MyAus app

Government app to help newcomers find services, in many languages
myausapp.com

Overseas drivers (Austroads)

How overseas licences are recognised, with links to each state's licensing authority
austroads.gov.au/drivers-and-vehicles/overseas-drivers/country-recognition



Always check the source

Rules, fees and services change. Treat these as starting points and confirm details with the organisation. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not registered migration agents.

Six steps, and someone beside you for each one

Moving country is a sequence of decisions. We take them with you in order, so you are never solving step five before step two is done.



STEP 1

Discovery call

A relaxed conversation about your profession, your family and what you want from a move. No forms, no pressure.



STEP 2

Eligibility & registration

We map your route to Ahpra registration and help you gather the evidence the regulator will ask for.



STEP 3

Opportunities & interviews

Roles matched to where you want to live and how you like to work, with honest briefings before every interview.



STEP 4

Offer & decision support

We help you read the offer properly: pay step, relocation support, roster and what the team is really like.



STEP 5

Visa & relocation guidance

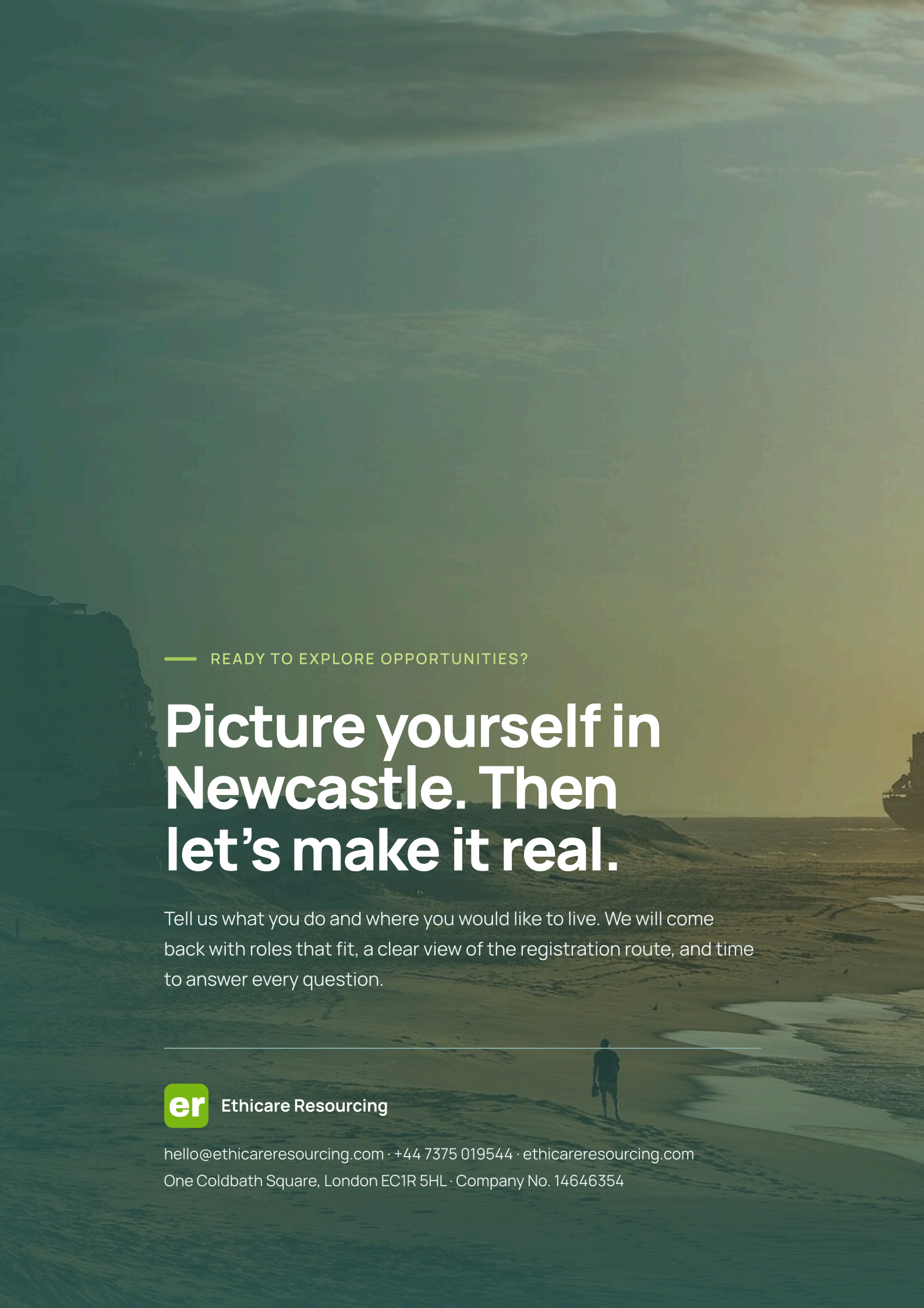
Practical guidance on visas, shipping, pets, schools and the first weeks, so nothing arrives as a surprise.



STEP 6

Settling in

We stay in touch after you land, from your first week on the ward to your first winter.



— READY TO EXPLORE OPPORTUNITIES?

Picture yourself in Newcastle. Then let's make it real.

Tell us what you do and where you would like to live. We will come back with roles that fit, a clear view of the registration route, and time to answer every question.



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